

Parent Guidelines

For Judging

Parliamentary Debate Tournaments

(Revised August 2025)



**Prepared by
Karen Kenyon, Coach
San Marin High School**

(Bring this guide with you to each tournament and read it over while you are waiting to be called to judge.)

Table of Contents

Debate - Our league offers 4 different kinds of debate: Parliamentary, Policy, Public Forum, and Lincoln-Douglas. Since our students compete in Parliamentary debate, that is the kind of debate you will generally be asked to judge. As such, this packet focuses on judging Parli debate. Policy and Lincoln-Douglas are very specialized types of debate and require judges to be EXTREMELY knowledgeable about it before judging it. If they ever ask you to judge Policy or Lincoln-Douglas, give an emphatic, “NO.” If your ballot tells you that you are judging Policy or Lincoln-Douglas, go up to the front desk and let them know you are not able to judge these kinds of debate. However, Public Form is doable, so if asked, you can probably judge this. Our league offers each type of debate at three experience levels -- Novice, Junior Varsity, and Varsity – and in your course of judging, you will judge all three levels.

Description of Parliamentary Debate.....	3
General Instructions for Judging Debate.....	5
San Marin Coach’s Personal Guidelines for Judging Any Debate Competition ...	7
A Sample Flow Sheet – a method for taking notes	9

Description of Parliamentary Debate

It is a form of extemporaneous debate where two teams debate a **proposition** (AKA a **resolution** or **motion**) that they receive only 20 minutes (30 minutes for Novice) before the round starts. One team affirms the proposition (is in favor of it) and one team negates the proposition (is against it). Teams do not get to decide which side they will be on – they are assigned a side. The teams have the 20 minutes to prepare their arguments and gather evidence.

The team in favor of the resolution is known by several names: the **Affirmation**, the **Government**, or the **Affirmative**. The team opposed to the resolution is known as the **Negative**, **Negation** or the **Opposition**.

The first Affirmative speaker may be referred to as the Prime Minister and the first negation speaker may be called the Leader of the Opposition.

Resolutions fall into three categories – Fact (statement of fact), Value (values are weighed as to importance), and Policy (a problem in the status quo is highlighted and the AFF team MUST present a simple plan to solve it.)

The debate consists of 4 constructive speeches where both sides will get to present their arguments and attempt to break down the other sides' arguments. The constructives are followed by two rebuttal speeches, one for each side. In the rebuttals, the teams try to present to the judge what they believe are the voting issues in the debate.

No NEW ARGUMENTS are allowed during rebuttals. There is NO prep time between speeches. Each speaker must be up to speak within 20 seconds of the person who spoke before. This is true for both constructive AND rebuttal speeches. Here are the times for the speeches at the Junior Varsity and Varsity levels:

Constructives:

First proposition (or Affirmation or Government) speech	7 minutes
First opposition (or Negation) speech	8 minutes
Second proposition (or Affirmation or Government) speech	8 minutes
Second opposition (or Negation) speech	8 minutes

Rebuttal speeches come last –

Opposition (Negation) rebuttal	4 minutes – <u>Given by the first opposition speaker</u>
Proposition (Affirmation) rebuttal	5 minutes – <u>Given by the first proposition speaker</u>

At the **Novice level**, the times are 5 minutes for each constructive and 3 minutes for each rebuttal.

Students use their prep time to learn more about the topic they were just given. During that time, they can access the Internet. However, they can only use their hand-written notes in the actual debate. They can use their phones only as timers. A student with a disability is allowed to use their computer. Students cannot cite AI as a source, but they could use CHAT GPT to help them generate arguments.

Students may begin their speeches with an off-time road map – this is where they tell you how they plan to organize their speaking time to help you follow along. However it should never contain any arguments. This off-time road map does not count as part of their time.

In the first AFF speech, you will generally hear the AFF tell you what kind of debate it is (Fact, Value, Policy), what they believe should be the judging criteria or the weighing mechanism that they hope you will use to decide the debate, and how the main or key terms in the debate should be defined. The NEG may get up in their speech and argue that they think there is a better judging criteria or that the definitions are unfair and why.

Primary emphasis in parliamentary debate is on the use of logic and generally available information. Students are encouraged to use all kinds of evidence to support their claims – they can use logic; personal experience; analogies; facts they learned in school, on TV, or in books; and facts they learned during their brief time of researching the topic. If they are using quotes or statistics from materials they researched, they should be giving a source for those facts and the quote or statistics should be written down in their notes in complete form with no ellipsis. The other side can ask to see the notes. They can protest the debate with you if the notes are not available in their entirety. In the past, students have sometimes, sadly, made up statistics and information to support their position, as well as sources, and we are trying to discourage this.

Parliamentary debate also has three other elements:

A Point of Information (POI) – This is when the team that is not speaking stands up to ask a question or make a statement to the speaker who is speaking. The question/comment can't last more than 15 seconds. It can only be asked if the person giving the speech says that they will take the question. Only one question may be asked at a time. If a student wishes to ask another question, he must again address the speaker. Questions cannot be asked during the first and last minute of a speech – this is called protected time.

Point of Clarification (POC) -- A Point of Clarification is a question that a member of the opposing team asks a debater during the first four constructive speeches. The question shall aim to clarify the speaker's case or interpretation of the resolution. (For instance, "What was your second contention?" or "Did you say that your plan will be administered under the Department of Justice?") The speaker may not decline a Point of Clarification. Speech time stops for Points of Clarification and resumes once they are answered.

Point of Order (POO) – A point of order is where one team believes the other team has done something wrong. Usually points of order are made during rebuttals. They generally involve two things: the students believe the team has just introduced a new argument in rebuttal (which is not allowed) or they believe the team went substantially overtime. In a point of order, the timer is stopped. The team explains in 15 seconds why they think the other team broke the rule, and that team has 15 seconds to explain to you why it did not. You as a judge get to decide if you believe the Point of Order is correct; if so, you generally disregard the new argument or any arguments presented during the extensive overtime when making your decision.

General Instructions for Judging Debates from the Golden Gate Speech Association

Thank you very much for donating your time. Without your help and support, this tournament would be impossible! Here is some information to familiarize you with the debate you are about to judge.

GENERAL PROCEDURE

- Your school is obligated to provide a certain number of judges for the day. If an emergency arises, and you need to leave, we need to know. We have to drop teams from the tournament if the judges from their school are not present.
- You must have a Tabroom account. Please go to www.tabroom.com to sign up.
- You need to have a laptop, a tablet, or a cell phone with you to judge. You will receive your judging assignments as an email from Tabroom. You can also always go to your Tabroom account to check for a judging assignment. Once you have the ballot, **push the START button IMMEDIATELY to show that you have received it. Do not wait to push start until the debate has started.** The tabroom needs to know that you have received your ballot and will be there to judge. After this, go to the assigned room. Here is a video on how to complete your Tabroom ballot:
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=c8dSkHnfb4>
- Sometimes, you will be given a “double flight” for the round – that means that you will judge two . Here is a good, short YouTube video on using Tabroom: different debates in that same room during that round. You will judge the first one, then submit your ballot, and then another two teams will come into the room for a second debate.
- Once in the room, ALWAYS check the students’ names against the names on your ballot. DO NOT ask students about their school affiliation.
- DO NOT give oral critiques to the students; do not reveal your decisions to the students.
- After the debate is over, DO fill in your decision on the Tabroom ballot completely. **You must render a decision and vote for either the affirmative or the negative side.** When you have your decision in Tabroom, send it in – even if you have not added your comments yet. We need the decision as soon as possible. In Tabroom, you can go back in and provide comments that explain the reason for your decision at a later time during the day. Please provide suggestions for improvement for the debaters. The students read your comments and use them to improve.
- If you have any problems (there are different kids in your room than the names listed on your ballot, you know some of the competitors personally, a team has not arrived, a student gets sick and needs to leave etc.), please let those running the tournament know ASAP. At each tournament they will let you know how to reach them.

MONITORING THE ROOMS:

The host school has generously donated its entire campus for our tournament. It is our goal that the teachers and school administrators return on Monday with no evidence of our having been here. **So please...**

- **Do not allow any food or drinks** in the classrooms. Ask the students to dispose of food outside the classroom so the ants do not visit over the weekend.
- **Do not allow the students to move furniture!** If it is absolutely necessary to move furniture in the room so students can speak, then ask students to put the room back the way they found it. Also, please watch to make sure nothing is taken from the room.
- **Do not allow students to erase** teacher material on the whiteboard. If students are using the whiteboard, make sure they use the correct pens and erase their material.
- **Do not allow ANYONE** to touch the teacher’s computer or personal items on the desk.
- **Be the last one to leave the room after the round – Do a quick glance around to make sure the room is exactly as your found it! Thanks!**

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS:

What if I've never judged before?

Don't worry! We want the students to learn to communicate with all audiences. Let them know that you would appreciate that they speak slowly, or that you are fairly new to judging. The kids should be able to adjust their delivery to accommodate your requests.

What if I discover that I know one of the contestants? The judging house staff will make every effort to ensure that you do not judge students from your school, and that you do not judge the same debaters twice at one tournament. However, mistakes do happen. It is very difficult to judge students whom you know, and it can be disconcerting for the students.

Please contact the judges' room and let them know if...

- you know a student in a group you are about to judge.
- you have already judged a debater at this tournament

Are students allowed to use computers at the debate?

Yes and No. Computers are allowed, but each kind of debate has different levels of computer use. You will need to check the specific rules for the kind of debate you are judging.

Are students allowed to use cellphones as timers?

Yes! CHSSA rules allow cellphones to be used as timers in all debate events. Cellphones must be used as timers only and must be set to airplane mode.

Should I take notes?

Taking notes during the debate will help you make a better decision and make it easier to give feedback to the students. And if you plan to write your comments later in the day, notes will help you remember that specific round.

What if I have a personal opinion about the issue being debated? Please try to put aside your personal views. The debaters do not choose their topic or the side that they must uphold. The debaters should not have to debate your personal beliefs, just the other side.

What should I do if I believe a violation of the rules has occurred?

Confusion or conflict about specific rules may arise while you are judging. The best course of action is for you to hear the speeches, make your evaluation of the debate as if there were no question about the rules, and then consult with tournament officials in the judges' room about the rules in question after the round is over. If the debate has been heard and evaluated completely, we can do a much better job of determining the best course of action.

Whom do I ask if I have a question about the rules?

Please direct all of your questions to the staff in the judges' room. They are there to help!

Do I have to keep track of time?

Usually the debaters do it themselves. Just clarify how they will do timing before the debate starts.

HELP FROM GOLDEN GATE SPEECH ASSOCIATION (OUR LEAGUE):

You can find lots of information about judging parliamentary debate on Tabroom. If you go to the website for the tournament you are judging, you will find lots of information on the right side of the page. Here is a link to guidelines for judging that was used at one of our tournaments:

https://www.tabroom.com/index/tourn/index.mhtml?webpage_id=29348&tourn_id=31312

Try to read up on judging BEFORE you go to your first debate.

The San Marin Coach's PERSONAL Guidelines and Tips for Judging Debate Competition

- Here's the BIGGEST thing to remember: Don't worry too much about whether your decision is right or wrong. Just do the best you can. By your being there, the kids are getting a chance to debate, and that alone will teach them huge amounts. And sometimes with beginners, it is almost impossible to tell who is winning or losing, trust me. Let's face it, one team will always think you made the wrong decision!
- Wear comfortable clothes and shoes. Rooms can be cold, so have a jacket or sweater. You don't need to bring food; lunch and snacks are provided for judges. You might want to have an insulated coffee cup with you. Bring a book and/or some things to do – you will have some downtime.
- Bring your laptop, tablet, or phone with you. (Tip: Phones can be difficult to use when trying to write your ballot, so laptops and tablets are preferable.) Make sure your device is fully charged. Also if you have an extra battery pack for it, it can be helpful. Usually there aren't many charging outlets that you can use.
- Keep checking Tabroom for your assignment. You won't have a debate assigned every round, but you need to be ready. Also when you get your ballot, be sure to check the box on Tabroom saying you are ready to START.
- Take notes on the main points being made by each debater – and try to write down the attacks made on those arguments. Debate is all about the arguments being made and the responses to those arguments. Without writing down the points, it is very difficult to decide who wins and who loses.
- Writing Comments:
 - At the top of your comments on your Tabroom ballot, write down the topic for that debate. The teams do at least four debates in a day, and they sometimes don't remember what the topic for the round was. My debaters tell me that seeing the topic as the first thing in the comments helps that a lot!
 - Write SOMETHING under "Reason for the Decision." Just getting a decision is NOT enough. You would be surprised how many judges don't write anything. It doesn't have to be a lot – maybe 3 or 4 sentences is enough.
 - Under each team, write some positive comments, but also give them some concrete feedback on ways to improve. It doesn't help our students if you say, "You were magnificent – You lose!" Feedback also helps their coaches know in what areas they need to be coaching. And know this – every debater reads their comments.
 - Be specific in your comments – A comment like "Your arguments are weak" or "The other team was stronger" doesn't help much. Your comments need to help them understand WHY they lost. For example, "I gave the debate to the Affirmation team because the negative failed to attack two of the Affirmative's main contentions. Since the judging criteria was net benefits, the AFF had 3 benefits from their plan and the negative only had one."
 - it is also important to give comments on both style AND content. While obviously, you CAN'T let your personal feelings about the content affect your decision, you CAN tell them that they need more facts to support their claims, that they need a more detailed plan, that they need to organize and number their arguments. And on the style front, tell them to slow down, to have more eye contact etc.
 - Be gentle – judges have actually written comments like, "Give it up – try folk dancing." Students want to improve but they can only take so much criticism. And for beginners, just getting up to debate is difficult enough – harsh comments can put an immediate end to their debate future.
 - Don't be afraid to write a couple of comments while the kids are speaking – I usually tell them, "Don't worry if you see me writing – I just want to write down some points while I remember." You can also tell your kids that you are "flowing the debate," which means that you are writing down the arguments and students' responses to those arguments. To be honest, we always tell judges to submit their decision and then go back to write comments, but it REALLY hard to

remember the comments you wanted to make after two hours have passed and you've listened to several debates in between, so I always encourage writing comments on your Tabroom ballot while the debate is happening

- You may hear students give incorrect information, but you can't count them down for this UNLESS the other team brings it up. I usually write in my comments that some of their facts were incorrect, but that I didn't make it part of my decision since the other side failed to mention it. Also some topics are controversial and you may have a strong opinion one way or another – PLEASE set your personal opinions aside and just judge what is introduced in the debate.
- Knock the kids hard if they are rude or if they make faces at the other competitors. If they are sarcastic, write it down on the ballot. Good sportsmanship in competition is NON-NEGOTIABLE! And their coaches want to know! However, unless it was egregious, it probably shouldn't cause you to change your decision.
- Sometimes a tournament will ask you to assign points to each speaker – most of our GGSA tournaments will not require that. If they ask you to assign points, we usually work with a point range of 24 – 30 points. You can give a low point win – This means that generally one team did a better job of debating, but the other side happened to present one argument that was, in your mind, a voting issue and a reason to give them the win. SO you give a "low point win. I suggest that you write this on your ballot – it helps to avoid confusion.
- If you need more time to write comments between speeches, tell the next student to wait a moment. Of course, you should only take about 15 extra seconds between speeches. But believe me when I say it helps to get your thoughts down BEFORE the next speaker starts.
- Points of Order – These were described above – the team making the POO is telling you they believe the other team did something that was unfair. Here's what a judge needs to keep in mind: When a Point of Order comes up, you, as the judge, do NOT need to tell the teams with whom you side – just say, "I will take it under advisement." If you side with the team that a new argument was made in rebuttals or that they went substantially overtime, you should NOT use those arguments in your decision.
- If you have special concerns, tell the kids – "I don't hear terribly well, so please speak up" or "I haven't judged debate before so speak slowly." Sometimes, the kids will ask for "your judging preferences" so be honest with what you like in debates. Remember, kids should be able to adapt to the needs or preferences of the judge. For me personally, speed and organization are REALLY important. I always tell my students, "Do you remember the philosophic question, 'If a tree falls in the woods, but nobody hears it, did it really make a sound?' Same is true in debate. If you make an argument so fast that the judge doesn't catch it, did you make the argument at all?"
- Kids will come up to shake your hand at the end of the round – if you prefer not to, just say so.
- If you aren't sure about how to handle a situation, go back to the judge's room and ask.
- Finally, complete your ballot as quickly as you can. We don't want to rush you, but if you take a really long time to complete your ballot, it can hold up the entire tournament

HONESTLY, ALL WE ASK IS THAT YOU GIVE THE STUDENTS A CHANCE TO COMPETE BY BEING "A CARING BODY IN THE ROOM." ANYTHING YOU CAN DO ABOVE AND BEYOND THIS IS A BONUS!

Below you will find an example of a flow sheet. This is a way to keep track of the main arguments and what each team said about them. As I make my decision, I circle on my flow sheet the arguments that I believe each side won. Then I can count who has the most wins – it is an easy way to decide.

Topic: All high school students should be required to wear uniforms.

SAMP
PAGE 1

1 AFF	1 NEG	2 AFF	2 NEG	NEG REB	AFF REB
policy, not ben. high school-public- funded gr. 9-12 uniform-required similar clothing	accept judging criteria def. of terms			Our voting issues ① Uniforms will not solve gang issues. Remember time mag evidence - gangs still in schools w/ uniforms - so AFF doesn't solve problem	Quick ANSWERS TO WINNING ISSUES OF NEG ① Bottom line - it will lessen influence, and whatever amount is better than what we have now!!
1. Eliminates gang influence @ school a. No gang colors like red b. No gang symbols c. Everyone looks same	1. Gang influence a. AFF doesn't tell how widespread or neg influence is b. Some schools -> no gangs/don't need c. Gangs will find other ways to identify themselves	US News 8/13/13 - Gang influence in schools increasing won't let gangs start in these schools a. Won't be easily visible	But putting uniforms on won't stop these gangs! Schools w/ uniforms - still have gangs - Time, 2/7/14 "Kids know" 2. Use tattoos, language hair to identify	② Students still allowed freedom of speech - just not w/ clothing while at school	② We show that they are just buying uniforms instead of other clothes. Went had to a significant loss of funding. Neg. didn't show otherwise
2. Eliminates economic disparity in clothes a. Clothes cost b. Families w/ little \$ can't afford c. Disparity between rich & poor d. Uniforms get rid of disparity	a. They will choose other way to show wealth - jewelry, phones etc. b. AFF doesn't document harm in this Also gets rid of individualism	a. Again, not as visible - More as part of uniform, a silly & No jewelry Herm - kids stand out as poor individual, or having stuff Chut pest - 10/2/13 Still plenty of things to be individual	"Jewelry" not part of def. of terms It will never regressed - Look at all anti-bullying stuff we still have School is where it counts Still no causal link - Kids now in school have distractions but still do well	③ Could adversely affect economy. ↓ It's spent on clothes ④ Hurts many teachers of clothing - leads to job loss ⑤ Less taxes collected - govt needs to cut	
3. Helps students focus on school - not fashion a. Provocative clothes distract b. Expensive clothes distract c. Removes distract d. Can focus on school	Kids are kids - if they don't want to focus, they won't no causal link - if uniforms -> they won't be distracted?	Removing distractions, so will focus more X	They dropped this argument		

Topic: All high school students should be required to wear uniforms.

SAMPLE PAGE 2

1 AFF	1 NEG	2 AFF	2 NEG	NEG REB	AFF REB
Plan - US Dept of Ed, mandate uniforms so w/ non-compliance = no red funds	① No funding → ② Should be done at local level - not nat ③ Bad precedent to set - "One shoe fits all" <u>NEG CASE</u> 1. Denies 1st Amend. Freedom of speech clothing = way to express self 2. Will hurt economy a. Limiting clothing purchases hurts manufacturers b. They will lay off workers c. Also not as much tax being paid 1. Tex cuts usually hurt poor the hardest. Obama - State of Union 2017	① No funding necessary - mandate it enough ② Fed. govt best - needs to be in ALL schools ③ "One shoe fits all" - if you mean equal for all, then we agree 1. Doesn't deny - kids can speak out still, can't dress on weekends etc. 2. Schools already limit freedoms - example - no rec rights before X-hood on campus b. No just switching to uniforms - still buying best have neg. impact 1. Again, will still get taxes. Govt hurt poor	① Need funding to make size schools comply ② Local communities better know their needs ③ No, we mean forcing all kids to be like everyone else. Kid - "Big Brother" tie 1. Amendment doesn't say "Freedom of speech" on weekends only - 24/7 2. And is that good? No, you're guaranteeing freedom all the time Uniforms cost less, so not as much revenue - still lay-offs and loss of taxes ↓ Poor impacted	<u>PRE-EMPT AFF</u> <u>UNIFORM ISSUES</u> 1. Socioeconomic disparity - If wealthy, will still continue in different terms 2. Will remove distractions - but we showed that no causal link	<u>AFF VOTING</u> ① It helps less wealthy kids - reduces bullying, creates level playing field ② The status quo is not doing it - we must do this at fed level. ③ Reduces gang influence and thus makes school safer for everyone!